Chapter Thirty-Six

The Birth of the Inquisition

Between 1215 and 1229,
the Fourth Lateran Council calls for crusade,
the Albigensian Wars end,
the Franciscan and Dominican orders are recognized,
and the Council of Toulouse authorizes a new form of inquiry

THROUGHOUT 1215, priests and bishops had been making their way to Rome: singly, in pairs, in bands, arriving at the great city and taking up temporary lodgings. The newly appointed Latin patriarch of Constantinople was among them. So were the senior churchmen from Acre and the other Crusader cities in the east. Ambassadors from the kings of France, England, Germany, and a score of other sovereigns joined them. Innocent III had summoned a church council, and the entire Western world had responded.

On November 11, the Fourth Lateran Council began.* There were, says Roger of Wendover, more than eight hundred abbots and priors in attendance, and over four hundred bishops and archbishops. Dominic de Guzman, who